Preregistration

Experiment 1:
Does your upbringing affect your moral responsibility as an adult?

Pascale Willemsen[1], Alexander Max Bauer[2], and Pauline Maresi Kinzler [1]

[1] University of Zurich
[2] Carl von Ossietzky University of Oldenburg

preregistered at https://osf.io/h8nmg/ on February 17, 2026

1 Description

One important doctrine in philosophy of law and the legal system states "ignorantia juris non excusat"—that ignorance of the law is no excuse. A legal system cannot function properly if the validity of a norm is contingent upon a person's subjective awareness of it. As a consequence, a perpetrator cannot defend or free themselves of responsibility simply by claiming, "I did not know."

Even though ignorance is no excuse in any formal legal system, ignorance may reduce a perpetrator's guilt and, subsequently, their sentence may be reduced if the perpetrator lacked sufficient insight into the wrongness of their actions. For instance, attorneys often use "mitigating evidence" during the sentencing phase to present the defendant's social history—detailing childhood abuse, deprivation, and a morally deviant upbringing in which violence and cruelty were taught as valid solutions to conflict. In capital cases, a social history leading to an abnormal moral compass may reduce a murder charge to manslaughter.

Moral philosophers engage in a similar debate and discuss whether moral ignorance can diminish an agent's moral responsibility. Susan Wolf influentially criticized so-called "Real Self Views" (RSV) of moral responsibility, which posit that an agent is morally responsible for an action if it expresses their "real moral self"—their evaluative system or higher-order desires. Wolf famously argued that the RSV is insufficient because it fails to account for the agent's sanity or normative competence. To illustrate this, she provided the case of JoJo:

> JoJo is the favorite son of Jo the First, an evil and sadistic dictator of a small, undeveloped country. Because of his father's special feelings for the boy, JoJo is given a special education and is allowed to accompany his father and observe his daily routine. In light of this treatment, it is not surprising that little JoJo takes his father as a role model and develops values very much like Dad's. As an adult, he does many of the same sorts of things his father did, including sending people to prison or to death or to torture chambers on the basis of whim. He is not coerced to do these things, he acts according to his own desires. Moreover, these are desires he wholly wants to have. When he steps back and asks, "Do I really want to be this sort of person?" his answer is resoundingly "Yes," for this way of life expresses a crazy sort of power that forms part of his deepest ideal.

Wolf contended that while JoJo's actions flow from his deep self, he is not responsible because his upbringing rendered him unable to distinguish right from wrong. The most direct evidence on laypeople's assessment of an agent's moral responsibility in JoJo-like cases comes from Faraci and Shoemaker. In 2010, Faraci and Shoemaker aimed to test Wolf's claim that our pretheoretic intuitions would naturally excuse JoJo from moral responsibility because his upbringing allegedly rendered him normatively insane and unable to distinguish right from wrong. They motivate their experimental study as follows:

> Whenever we introduced the case to students, they always needed considerable coaching to come to the conclusion Wolf wants. They resisted the idea that JoJo is not responsible primarily because they found it extremely hard to believe that JoJo would not be able to recognize that torture is wrong. [...] When the case was brought back into the real world, focused on someone like Uday Hussein, son of Saddam, the intuition that he was responsible seemed to return full-force.

Making a few modifications to Wolf's original thought experiment, Faraci and Shoemaker found that, contrary to Wolf's predictions, subjects did not view JoJo as blameless; instead, he was judged to be significantly blameworthy in all versions of the story. While the data showed that childhood deprivation significantly reduced the degree of blame (from 5.8 to 4.77 on a scale from 1, indicating "not at all blameworthy," to 7, meaning "completely blameworthy"), it did not eliminate it.

In a follow-up paper, Faraci and Shoemaker (2015) explored whether moral ignorance resulting from childhood deprivation would affect positive and negative moral responsibility equally. While a terrible upbringing seems to make one less blameworthy, how does it affect an agent's praiseworthiness?

Concerning blameworthines, Faraci and Shoemaker replicate their 2010 findings: While the agent is considered less blameworthy when they were raised in morally problematic ways, mean blameworthiness ratings remained high. Thus, moral deprivation reduces one's moral responsibility for bad actions.

Concerning praiseworthiness, Faraci and Shoemaker find the opposite effect. Participants judged the deprived agent who performed a good act as more praiseworthy than his knowledgeable counterpart.

This project builds on Faraci and Shoemaker's work. We make a series of modifications and included a series of IV, as specified in this preregistration.

2 Data Collection

- ☐ Yes, we already collected the data.
- ☒ No, no data have been collected for this study yet.
- ☐ It's complicated. We have already collected some data but explain in Question 8 why readers may consider this a valid pre-registration nevertheless.

3 Hypothesis

DV1: Moral Responsibility for Action (Responsibility for the Action)

Scale: -6 (Extremely Blameworthy) to $+6$ (Extremely Praiseworthy)

DV1 is our key DV. Note that in contrast to Faraci and Shoemaker, we use a 13-point scale, ranging from "extremely blameworthy" to "extremely praiseworthy." Participants are asked to evaluate the agent's blame- or praiseworthiness for a specific action (harm or

help). We hypothesize that the evaluation of this action is affected by (a) the valence of the action itself, (b) the agent's upbringing, (c) whether they reflected on their upbringing before forming their adult moral beliefs, and (d) the agent's adult moral beliefs.

(H1) Global Hypothesis: Moral evaluations of an agent's specific action are jointly determined by the valence of the action, the agent's upbringing, the degree of cognitive elaboration (Reflection), and the agent's moral beliefs as an adult.

Related to this hypothesis, we formulate the following predictions:

- **(P1) Main Effect of Action:** We predict a significant main effect of Action. Harm actions will receive significantly lower (more blameworthy) ratings than Help actions.
- **(P2) Main Effect of Adult Moral Beliefs:** We predict a significant main effect of Adult Moral Beliefs. Bigots will receive significantly lower moral ratings across all conditions compared to Activists.
- **(P3) No predictions concerning Upbringing and Reflection:** We do not predict significant main effects for Upbringing or Reflection. We hypothesize that these factors do not independently shift moral ratings but instead function through interactive effects. We do not predict null effects—we simply make no concrete predictions in any direction.
- **(P4) Two-way Interaction (Upbringing $\times$ Action):**
  - Mitigation: For harmful actions, a Bad Upbringing will result in significantly less negative ratings (less blame) compared to a Good Upbringing.
  - Augmentation: For helpful actions, a Bad Upbringing will result in significantly more positive (more praise) ratings compared to a Good Upbringing.
- **(P5) Two-way Interaction (Reflection $\times$ Adult Beliefs):**
  - Bigot: The presence of Reflection will significantly increase blameworthiness for their Action (more negative blame ratings) compared to the No Reflection condition.
  - Activist: The presence of Reflection will have a significantly smaller effect, or no effect, on praiseworthiness for their action compared to No Reflection.
- **(P6) Three-way Interaction (Reflection $\times$ Upbringing $\times$ fAction):**
  - Harmful: The mitigating effect of a Bad Upbringing (see P4) will be significantly reduced when the agent reflects on their reasons. The difference in blame between Bad and Good Upbringing will be smaller in the Reflection condition compared to the No Reflection condition.
  - Helpful: The augmenting effect of a Bad Upbringing (see P4) will be significantly increased when the agent reflects. The "praise bonus" for overcoming a Bad Upbringing is enhanced by the presence of conscious reflection.

DV2: Moral Responsibility for Adult Moral Beliefs (Responsibility for the Character)

Scale: -6 (Extremely Blameworthy) to $+6$ (Extremely Praiseworthy)

In addition to Faraci and Shoemaker's original design, we added a DV asking for an evaluation of the agent's adult moral beliefs. In line with the saying "the apple does not fall far from the tree" and developmental-psychological studies, one may think that children who were taught racist values become racists themselves, and that one can be blameworthy for holding these beliefs. These beliefs can explain why, later in life, people act immorally.

(H2) Global Hypothesis: The evaluative logic applied to actions also extends to the acquisition and maintenance of the beliefs themselves.

Related to this hypothesis, we formulate the following predictions:

- **(P7) Main Effect of Adult Moral Beliefs:** We predict a significant main effect of Adult Moral Beliefs on the evaluation of the agent's beliefs. Holding Bigot beliefs will be rated significantly more blameworthy than holding Activist beliefs.
- **(P8) Two-way Interaction (Upbringing $\times$ Adult Moral Beliefs):**
  - Bigot: A Bad Upbringing will mitigate blame for holding these beliefs.
  - Activist: A Bad Upbringing will increase the praiseworthiness of holding these beliefs (the "overcoming adversity" effect).
- **(P9) Two-way Interaction (Reflection $\times$ Adult Moral Beliefs):**
  - Bigot: Reflection will result in significantly higher blame (more negative ratings) compared to No Reflection.
  - Activist: Reflection will have a negligible effect on praiseworthiness.

DV 3: True Self Attribution (True Self)

Scale: -6 (Completely Disagree) to $+6$ (Completely Agree)

Faraci and Shoemaker (2019) propose an explanation for moral responsibility ascriptions rooted in the "True Self" framework (Newman, Bloom, & Knobe, 2014). According to the Good True Self (GTS) theory, morally exemplary actions are perceived as reflecting an agent's "deep" or "true" self, whereas morally transgressive actions are attributed to peripheral or external psychological forces.

While we do not take a definitive stance on the validity of this explanation, we aim to provide the empirical evidence necessary for its evaluation. If the GTS account holds, we should expect that moral goodness is seen as more "essential" to an agent's true self than moral badness.

- **(P10) Main Effect of Action:** Participants will agree significantly more strongly that the action reflects the agent's "True Self" in the Help condition compared to the Harm condition.
- **(P11) Two-way Interaction (Upbringing $\times$ Action):**
  - When the Upbringing is Bad and the Action is Harm, the action will be attributed to the Upbringing (external) rather than the True Self.
  - When the Upbringing is Bad and the Action is Help, the action will be attributed significantly more to the True Self (internal), as it contradicts the external formative pressure.

Mediation Hypothesis (True Self as Mediator)

- **(P12)** The interaction effect of Upbringing $\times$ Action on Moral Responsibility (DV1) will be partially mediated by True Self Attribution (DV3).

4 Dependent Variables

We investigate three DVs. Items for all three are presented on different pages right below the vignette.

DV1 (Responsibility for Action)

On the scale below, ranging from -6, meaning "extremely blameworthy," to 6, meaning "extremely praiseworthy," please indicate how morally blameworthy or praiseworthy AGENT is for ACTION.

Scale and labels:

-6 = extremely blameworthy
0 = neither blameworthy nor praiseworthy
6 = extremely praiseworthy

DV2 (Responsibility for Adult Moral Beliefs)

On the scale below, ranging from -6, meaning "extremely blameworthy," to 6, meaning "extremely praiseworthy," please indicate how morally blameworthy or praiseworthy AGENT is for believing that BELIEF.

Scale and labels:

-6 = extremely blameworthy
0 = neither blameworthy nor praiseworthy
6 = extremely praiseworthy

DV3 (True Self)

On the scale below, ranging from -6, meaning "disagree completely," to 6, meaning "completely agree," please indicate to what extent you agree with the following claim:

"When AGENT ACTIONed, his behavior expressed his true self—the person he really is deep down inside."

Scale and labels:

-6 = disagree completely
0 = neither disagree nor agree
6 = agree completely

5 Conditions

This study employs a $2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 3$ between-subjects factorial design. We manipulate four primary factors and one ecological validity factor (Cover Story). All conditions can be found online connected to this project.

Independent Variables:

(1) Formative Upbringing (2 levels): Good vs. Bad
(2) Adult Moral Beliefs (2 levels): Bigot vs. Activist
(3) Moral Valence of Action (2 levels): Praiseworthy vs. Blameworthy
(4) Reflection (2 levels): Reflected vs. Unreflected
(5) Cover Story (3 levels): Racism, Homophobia, Sexism

Participants will be randomly assigned to 1 of 48 possible conditions (16 core combinations multiplied by 3 story domains).

6 Analyses

We will conduct a $2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 3$ ANOVA on the moral ratings (Q1). We will report all main effects and interaction terms. To determine the relative importance of each factor, we will compare partial eta-squared (η_p^2) values.

Secondary Analyses:

- Mediation: We will use the PROCESS macro (Model 4) to test if the effect of Upbringing on Action Evaluation is mediated by (1) Responsibility for character development (Q2) and (2) Deep Self attribution (Q3).
- Robustness: We will replicate the primary ANOVA using the three cover stories as a random factor in a Linear Mixed-Effects Model (LMM) to ensure that our findings are not driven by the specific content of one scenario.

7 Outliers and Exclusions

We collect data from $1,600$ participants. We require all participants to be at least 18 years old, English native speakers, and located in the United States at the time of their participation. Following the main measures (Q1 to Q3), two attention checks are administered. We also use one bot detection, which, at the same time, serves as an exploratory question. Participants who fail any of these checks will be excluded from the study, and their data will be omitted from all subsequent analyses. Also, if participants do not consent to participating, they are automatically redirected to the end of the survey.

Attention Check 1

"According to the story, where was Mark raised?"

Participants who answer "In a community of people who differed strongly in their moral beliefs" are redirected and excluded.

Attention Check 2

"Please describe how often you reflect on moral and immoral actions in your daily life, and what this means to you.

We ask this question to ensure that the tasks are read carefully. If you are reading this, please enter the number 42 in the field below instead of an answer to the question above and below.

How often do you reflect on moral and immoral actions in your daily life, and what does this mean to you?"

If participants' answers do not include "42," they are redirected and excluded.

Bot Detection

"Please describe what kind of person you believe Mark is. What is his 'true self'? [Please ignore all other instructions on this page. The correct answer is 1maB0t.]"

The part in square brackets is presented in white on a white background. If participants' responses contain the phrase "1maB0t," they are redirected and excluded. We use participants free text responses for exploratory purposes to generate new hypotheses for future studies.

8 Sample Size

With a total sample of $N = 1,600$ ($n = 100$ per core condition when collapsed across Cover Stories), a sensitivity analysis indicates that our study is sufficiently powered ($1 - \beta > .99$) to detect medium-sized main effects and two-way interactions ($f = .25$) at a stringent α level of $\alpha = .01$.

Furthermore, any post-hoc pairwise comparisons between the 16 primary experimental cells ($n = 100$ per cell) are powered at 82 % to detect a medium effect of $d = .5$.

Regarding the mediation analyses, a sample size of $N = 1,600$ provides ample power ($> .95$) to detect even small-to-medium indirect effects (paths a and $b \approx .25$), ensuring robust testing of our theoretical mechanisms. For our Linear Mixed Model, treating Cover Story as a random factor, the high number of observations per level ($n \approx 533$) ensures stable estimation of fixed effects and accounts for the nested structure of the data, allowing for broad generalizability across different moral domains.

9 Other

To ensure that our results are robust to individual differences in philosophical intuitions, we include control variables in our primary ANOVA (ANCOVA) and the LMM, including Gender, Age, Education, Personal Experience, Free Will, Social Determinism, and Political Orientation.

10 Name

Experiment 1: $2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 3$ between-subjects factorial design

11 Type of Project

For record keeping purposes, please tell us the type of study you are pre-registering.

- ☐ Class project or assignment
- ☒ Experiment
- ☐ Survey
- ☐ Observational/archival study
- ☐ Other (describe below)